

"Polio": Infantile Paralysis

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK "POLIO": INFANTILE PARALYSIS ***

[Illustration:

?Polio?

INFANTILE PARALYSIS

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When polio strikes some child in a community, it is only natural for all parents in that community to become concerned about their own children. It is well to keep in mind, however, that even during an epidemic the number of persons who get the disease is very small

in comparison with the total population. For example, approximately 45,000 cases were reported for the entire United States and Canada in 1949??and this was a bad year.

[Illustration]

Furthermore, about 50% of those who get polio seriously enough to become paralyzed recover completely. Another large group has very slight after-effects. Comparatively few are seriously affected by the disease, and many of these can be considerably improved by means of surgery and prolonged special treatment. Very few cases end fatally.

This does not mean, however, that polio can safely be ignored. The disease is a serious one??it is the most frequent cause of deformity in children??and wise parents will take every possible precaution to help their children avoid contracting it.

What is POLIO?

It is a contagious disease in which the gray matter of the spinal cord is attacked, producing destruction of certain cells and causing paralysis. The disease is caused by a virus??tiny ?bugs? smaller than bacteria. Apparently these ?bugs? enter through the mouth on food or in water that has been contaminated in some fashion, or through the nose in breathing. It is not conclusively known how the disease is spread. Many people harbor the virus without any reaction whatsoever. Many others have mild symptoms which they disregard as a summer cold. Once symptoms have developed, special laboratory studies made by experts are usually carried out to establish the diagnosis accurately.

What are the SYMPTOMS?

There is no characteristic symptom or sign to be found in all cases. This makes the diagnosis difficult. Quite frequently, the patient cannot bend his head forward as far as usual. A doctor should always be called if anyone in the family has a fever associated with a bad headache, or with pain in the muscles in either the arms or legs or in the neck and back. Even minor upsets in children should be looked upon with suspicion. Nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, a slight cold coupled with pain in the joints, are also possible danger signs. A child catching polio may become drowsy or restless, feverish and irritable. He may complain about and resist being moved. These symptoms are particularly important during the summer and early fall months because this is the period during which most outbreaks of polio occur.

What is the TREATMENT?

If, during the course of an epidemic, any suspicious illness should develop in a member of your family, prompt medical attention and

observation are important. If any sign or symptom of polio is present, the affected person should be hospitalized immediately. Hospitals have many special forms of equipment which are necessary in treatment. Trained nursing care is essential. Should paralysis appear, special measures are necessary to prevent or lessen deformity and to begin the rebuilding of the affected parts of the body. No clearly reliable specific drug is available as yet which will cure polio, but gamma globulin appears to give some degree of protection for several weeks against the paralysis stage of the disease. There are now strong hopes that a vaccine is now available that will give immunity against polio for a whole season.

At the present time treatment of the disease takes many forms. While a patient is recovering from a polio attack, a full nourishing diet, application of various forms of heat and massage, special baths and exercises, are the measures which are most helpful in restoring usefulness to affected arms or legs. Specially built shoes or braces are required in only a few cases, and surgical operations have been devised to return motion and function to the arms or legs of some patients.

Treatment must be continued over long periods of time in some cases, but the results are often very rewarding. The expense of such long treatment is great. Fortunately, an awakened public, through its contributions to the National Foundation for Infantile Paralysis and other Agencies, has helped thousands to bear this expense. Support of these organizations in their sincere and unselfish aims is a splendid public service in the battle against polio.

[Illustration]

How to GUARD against this DISEASE....

Although there is no known means of vaccination or inoculation against polio, many things can be done to lessen the possibility of getting the disease.

First of all, if an epidemic occurs, you should follow the instructions of the local public health officer. He will also decide in what cases gamma globulin is needed.

Secondly, it is wise to avoid crowded places, especially indoors where there is opportunity for close contact and possible infection.

In addition, food and water should be obtained only from absolutely reliable sources.

Every effort should be made to insure that flies, mice, rats, and other vermin are kept out of the home, as they are possible carriers of infection.

You and your children should get plenty of rest and wholesome food, avoid over-exertion and excessive fatigue.

Do not travel into areas where there is much polio or go swimming when many cases have occurred in your locality.

Further, many physicians may advise postponing the removal of tonsils, the extraction of teeth, or other operations in or about the nose, throat, or mouth when the disease is prevalent in the community.

[Illustration]

The National Foundation for Infantile Paralysis and other Agencies will help polio patients as much as possible. But the best kind of help is that which you, yourself, can give by taking every precaution to keep the disease from striking anyone in your family. Proper rest, a balanced diet, and moderate exercise in the fresh air and sunshine tone up the body and help increase the system's resistance to disease. By following these and other common-sense rules of wholesome living, your family will be taking a major step toward health and happiness.

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